

A Room Without a View

Justin

I know the difference between a feeling and a fact.

I know the difference between an assumption and an observation.

I know the difference between a reaction and the sequence that produced it.

I know the difference between a feeling that is real and a feeling that can hold weight as evidence.

I know the difference between being seen and being known.

I know the difference between being seen and being defined.

I know the difference between being uncared for and being unrecognized inside someone else's definition of care.

I know the difference between upholding a boundary and evading accountability.

I know the difference between being a winner and being right.

I know the difference between confirmation and proof.

I know the difference between explaining myself and being understood.

I know the difference between being nice and needing to be seen as nice.

I know the difference between remaining and disappearing the moment someone else sounds convinced.

These are not refinements.

They are the floor.

A life changes depending on whether the room can tell them apart.

Mine did.

A feeling can be real and still fail as evidence.

An assumption can sound intelligent and still not be an observation.

A reaction can look unreasonable when the sequence that produced it has been removed.

Being seen can feel like intimacy until the seeing hardens into definition.

Care can miss so completely that the cared-for person disappears inside someone else's performance of care.

A boundary can be real and still not answer for
the part of the story someone is avoiding.

Evading accountability can borrow the language
of self-protection and still leave the burden un-
touched.

A winner needs the room.

Right does not.

Confirmation can flatter a story without proving
it.

Explanation can leave my body perfectly and still
never become understanding.

Niceness can be a gift.

Needing to be seen as nice can become a room
where truth goes to be managed.

And I have spent too much of my life disappear-
ing the moment someone else sounded convinced.

That was the old arrangement.

Someone spoke with certainty.

I checked myself.

Someone named me.

I considered it.

Someone remembered less than I did and sounded
calmer doing it.

I bent toward the possibility that calm meant ac-
curacy.

Someone told me how I seemed.

I let seeming enter the room as evidence.
Someone said they understood me.
I looked for myself in what they understood.
Someone said they loved me.
I believed love meant they would keep looking.
That was what I wanted.
Not to be agreed with.
Not to be admired.
Not to be summarized correctly enough that the
room could move on.
Known.
I wanted to be known.
Known is not being noticed.
Known is not being desired.
Known is not being useful.
Known is not someone collecting enough details
to make a convincing version of me.
Known means the sequence is allowed to matter.
Known means the contradiction does not get
swept away because someone's feeling changed.
Known means the thing I said remains attached to
the moment I said it.
Known means my care is not erased because it did
not produce the feeling someone wanted from it.
Known means my apology does not become a
storage unit for everything that happened.

Known means I do not have to vanish just because someone else sounds finished.

I remember what people say to me.

Not everything.

I lose scissors.

I lose the hair dryer.

I lose objects the second they become ordinary.

But I remember the sentence that changed the room.

I remember what it permitted.

I remember what it cost.

I remember when a word arrived as care and left as control.

I remember when a decision arrived dressed as us.

I remember when the story changed and I was expected to keep walking as if the floor had not moved.

No.

The floor moved.

I felt it.

I know the difference.

That is who I am.